

Secret Google Server

Google has an ultra clandestine data center in Dallas, Oregon but searches (online and offline) don't give any useful results.

SCI-TECH

popular pages get crawled early because many pages link to them. Google predominantly calculates relevancy by the number of incoming links to that page, which is called PageRank. This is a safe way of calculating relevancy, as it disallows the content creator from manipulating his/her page to boost relevancy. However, this has often been abused by a lot of people "bombing" a site by linking to it, to boost its PageRank (called googlebombing). Other search engines use a proprietary mixture of considerations. These considerations include the number of times a searched word has appeared in a document, whether or not it appears in bold text, how many times it appears in the links, in sub-headings and in the title. Other considerations include the neighbouring pages, the frequency of site updates and even whether or not the owner has paid the search engine. An important consideration is the geographic origin of the content and the location of the user originating the search query.

Typically, pages created in the same country as the searcher get a higher relevance. An Indian looking for "news" would likely have no interest in the news web sites of Belarus. Relevancy is also calculated using meta-tags in the page. Meta-tags exist specifically for search engines, where the content creator includes keywords in the document, explaining what the document is about. Keyword spamming is where a creator uses a lot of keywords to get hits, most of which have no relevance to the content of the page. Search engines automatically match meta-tags with the content of the page, and accordingly judge the relevancy. Some search engines such as Google and Yahoo! penalise keyword spammers by reducing their relevancy.

Many web site creators try hard to optimise their sites in such a way that they become more relevant for search returns. This includes artificially boosting the number of incoming links, using the right keywords in the meta-tags, formatting the page properly, and a number of other methods. Many of these are transparent, but a lot are clandestine. Optimising a particular web site for search engines is a very lucrative business. A third party may work on a site between the creator and the search engine. Due to the aggressive nature of search engine optimisation, all search engines continuously change the methods for relevance ranking, and keep the exact methods used, a secret.

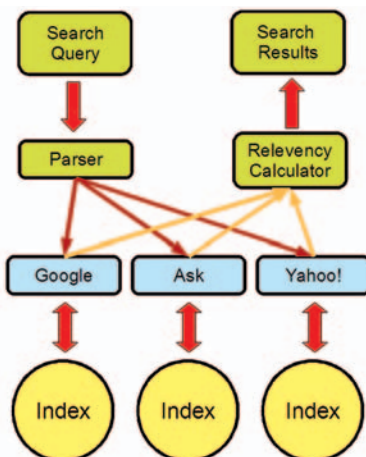
Deep magic

As the web moves away from the domain of personal computers into portable devices such as PMPs and mobile phones, search engines will also spread out to these technologies. Geo-tagging will take on more of a hold, which means you can search while on the move. Products and services in the real world will be more easily integrated with the virtual alternatives.

Google cannot afford to move away from its minimalistic design. Search, however, does not end at Google. There are a whole bunch of interesting search engines waiting to be found. Swicki (www.eurekster.com) let's you build your own search engine. Chacha (www.chacha.com) answers questions the way good-old Jeeves used to, and even replies to SMS. Gnod (www.gnod.net) has tools for searching movies, music or books similar to what you already like. Results are displayed in a spatial map of similarity. Clusty (<http://clusty.com/>) breaks down results in clusters, which let you refine your searches.

In recent years, there has been a new breed of search engines that have made their presence felt. These are meta-search engines that do not have indexes or databases of their own, but work off the indexes and databases of other search engines. When a search query is entered in the search forms of these search engines, the search engine will retrieve the results from the databases of Google, Yahoo!, Ask and others. Mamma (www.mamma.com) or Dogpile (www.dogpile.com) are two very popular examples of meta-search engines. ■

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A meta-search engine at work



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